

AI data centers are forcing dirty 'peaker' power plants back into service

Posted by u/EchoOfOppenheimer • 0 points • 8 comments

The AI boom is officially reversing the green energy transition. A new Reuters investigation reveals that skyrocketing electricity demand from data centers is forcing the U.S. grid to resurrect obsolete peaker power plants-inefficient, 1960s-era fossil fuel units that were scheduled for demolition. In places like Chicago's Pilsen neighborhood, these dirty facilities are being kept online to prevent blackouts, concentrating pollution in low-income communities just to keep the servers running.

Comments

u/bayruss • 2 points • 2026-01-25 06:51 UTC

Tariffs and a cold war with China is why we can't afford renewables.

u/ClimateResilient • 1 points • 2026-01-23 23:34 UTC

We want renewables to replace fossil fuels, but that's extremely difficult when growth in energy demand outpaces our ability to build renewables. Renewables require a ton of metals, and a full energy transition is [bottlenecked by mining](<https://news.umich.edu/copper-cant-be-mined-fast-enough-to-electrify-the-us/>) (mainly the permitting process, which is valid as the ecological impacts aren't minor).

So despite rapid growth in the renewables sector, we're burning [far more coal, oil, and natural gas] (<https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/global-energy-substitution>) than we were 5 years ago. And as long as energy demand outpaces growth in renewable infrastructure, this will continue to be the case. A sustainable future requires changing our energy sources *and* lowering total energy consumption; AI isn't helping with either.

There's no solution to the climate crisis that doesn't involve pumping the brakes on unchecked growth.

u/Economy-Fee5830 • 2 points • 2026-01-23 23:45 UTC

> And as long as energy demand outpaces growth in renewable infrastructure, this will continue to be the case.

There is no way this will be the case - renewables is growing much faster than demand is growing - planning for energy scarcity is not sensible.:

****Solar generation additions (TWh):****

- 2021: ~225
- 2022: ~270
- 2023: ~320
- 2024: ****474**** (+48%)
- 2025: ~498 in just 9 months (+31% YoY)

This is exponential growth. Solar alone grew 48% in 2024. Yet they average this to "~355 TWh/year" and project it linearly to 2030.

If solar maintains even 25% annual growth (well below the recent 29-31%), it's adding ****1,500+ TWh** annually by 2030** - dwarfing their entire projected demand increase from AI, EVs, and cooling combined.

At 25% compound growth, 2025-2030 additions equal around 5,600 TWh, all without anyone needing to give up SUV or AI.

u/ClimateResilient • 1 points • 2026-01-24 00:09 UTC

>renewables is growing much faster than demand is growing - planning for energy scarcity is not sensible.

If that were the case, we would be seeing a corresponding decrease in global fossil fuel consumption. I also don't think "scarcity" is an appropriate word to use for a society that's increased its energy use by 1,500% in under a century.

>If solar maintains even 25% annual growth (well below the recent 29-31%), it's adding 1,500+ TWh annually by 2030 - dwarfing the entire projected demand increase from AI, EVs, and cooling combined.

The IEA projects total growth in renewable capacity to reach [4,600 gigawatts by 2030](<https://www.iea.org/news/global-renewable-capacity-is-set-to-grow-strongly-driven-by-solar-pv>), which represents about 50% of our [current electricity capacity](<https://www.eia.gov/international/data/world/electricity/electricity-capacity>). However, the IEA also projects that [fossil fuel demand will continue to rise through 2050](<https://archive.is/3FVxT>) (remember that electricity capacity and primary energy consumption are very different things).

So in short, ****growth in energy demand is projected to outpace renewable power generation.**** AI isn't the sole contributor, of course, but it's [certainly not helping](<https://www.iea.org/reports/energy-and-ai/energy-demand-from-ai>).

>all without anyone needing to give up SUV or AI.

Even if that weren't the case, that's a miserable prognosis for the natural world. Why would we [stretch our natural resources to the brink](https://data.footprintnetwork.org/?_ga=2.260034895.431845434.1769213206-1740570250.1767374442#/countryTrends?cn=5001&type=BCtot,EFCtot) just to consume things that don't make us happier or healthier?

u/Economy-Fee5830 • 0 points • 2026-01-24 00:20 UTC

> If that were the case, we would be seeing a corresponding decrease in global fossil fuel consumption. I also don't think "scarcity" is an appropriate word to use for a society that's increased its energy use by 1,500% in under a century.

In places with a huge amount of renewables we are and in other places we see a reduction in the growth of fossil fuels.

> However, the IEA also projects that fossil fuel demand will continue to rise through 2050

This was just at Trump's behest - first IEA predictions are not worth the toilet paper they are written on and secondly their latest ones are under political pressure.

<https://preview.redd.it/iea-forecasting-will-always-be-funny-v0-twy7j17usmuf1.jpeg?auto=webp&s=12bf34f2911957273b755e4181fdd62013b8338b>

<https://www.politico.eu/article/donald-trump-official-pressure-international-energy-agency-drop-climate-mission/>

> If that's true, that's a miserable prognosis for the natural world.

You could have just started by saying you are an ecofascist.

u/ClimateResilient • 0 points • 2026-01-24 00:56 UTC

>You could have just started by saying you are an ecofascist.

And that's how you end a good-faith debate.

u/Economy-Fee5830 • -1 points • 2026-01-24 00:57 UTC

> And that's how you end a good-faith debate.

Well, I don't believe ecofascists ever argue in good faith - they just pretend to care about people until the mask comes off.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-01-24 03:04 UTC
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u/Economy-Fee5830 • -1 points • 2026-01-24 09:48 UTC

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Assoc>